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Sept. 3, 2026

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Gov. Braun Awards Grant to Transform Rural Healthcare in East-Central Indiana Region

Indianapolis, IN- Gov. Mike Braun announced today that the east central Indiana region (Region 4) has been awarded \$15.2 million in Growing Rural Opportunities for Well-being (GROW) initiative grants. GROW region four includes Blackford, Fayette, Grant, Henry, Jay, Madison, Randolph, Tipton, Union, Wayne counties.

GROW is focused on improving healthcare access, quality and outcomes in rural communities across the state of Indiana and supported by the Indiana Rural Health Transformation Program (RHTP), administered by the Indiana Department of Health (IDOH) and Family and Social Services Administration (FSSA). Indiana received nearly \$207 million for the first year of the five-year federal Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services (CMS) grant program. About \$120 million, or 60% of that funding, was earmarked for the regional grants.

"The Trump Administration's Rural Health Transformation Program is based on one simple idea: your access to quality health care shouldn't depend on your ZIP code," said CMS Administrator Dr. Mehmet Oz. "Funding new approaches to expand access and improve health outcomes for rural Hoosiers is an important step toward achieving that vision and I look forward to seeing RHTP dollars support equally transformative innovations for rural communities nationwide."

"This funding is a major step forward in our commitment to making health care affordable and accessible for all Hoosiers," Gov. Braun said. "It's an important stride toward creating a more sustainable and connected network in rural Indiana."

Region 4 GROW grant activities include:

- **Expand community-based access to care:** Build stronger community health worker networks, mobile integrated health, rural mobile clinics, and coordinated transportation, including a CHW regional network, MIH home-based assessments, rural mobile clinic deployments and a regional transportation plan that reduces missed appointments and strengthens access across all counties.

- **Implement a regionwide maternal health access model:** Bring prenatal/postpartum care into homes and community settings; expand navigation, remote patient monitoring, maternal education and other direct perinatal support services; and integrate behavioral health/SUD treatment into maternal care workflows to address high-risk outcomes.
- **Transform behavioral health and crisis response:** Utilize ED embedded clinicians, a new adolescent inpatient psychiatric unit, standardized regional crisis services messaging and dedicated behavioral health transport, all aimed at reducing preventable ED utilization, crisis boarding, and out of region transfers.
- **Strengthen emergency medical response and rural clinical readiness:** Expand MICU critical care transport and prehospital blood access across 12 counties.
- **Build a long-term rural healthcare workforce pipeline:** Support career pathway expansion, employer sponsored EMT/paramedic cohorts, externship and clinical placement supports, preceptor development, rural training clinics and expansion of sonography and other high demand programs.

Rural Health Transformation Program's GROW will now move into implementation building on a foundation of strong collaboration, local leadership and meaningful impact from targeted activities.

Region 4's award complements the seven other regions that received GROW regional grants. RHTP also includes 11 statewide initiatives that promote workforce investment, thoughtful partnerships and infrastructure development. Additional information about the GROW regional grants and 11 statewide initiatives are available on the RHTP website growruralhealth.in.gov.

This Rural Health Transformation Program is supported by the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) as part of a financial assistance award totaling \$206,927,896.80 with 100 percent funded by CMS/HHS. The contents are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily represent the official views of, nor an endorsement, by CMS/HHS, or the U.S. Government.

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